

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
EASTERN DISTRICT OF NEW YORK

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IAN FLETCHER,

Plaintiff, **COMPLAINT**

-against-

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

THE CITY OF NEW YORK; NYPD P.O. ESTEBAN
TAX ID # 943213; SGT DEPSTRE TAX ID #
932535; P.O. JOHN/JANE DOES #1-10; the
individual defendant(s) sued individually
and in their official capacities,

Defendants.

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PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights, common law, and tort action in which plaintiff seeks relief for the violation of his rights secured by the laws of the State of New York; New York State Constitution; 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983 and 1988; and the Fourth, Sixth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution. Plaintiff's claims arise from an incident that took place on August 9, 2014. During the incident, the City of New York, and members of the New York City Police Department ("NYPD") subjected plaintiff to, among other things, unlawful search and seizure, excessive force, false arrest, failure to intervene, and implementation and continuation of an unlawful municipal policy, practice, and custom, and respondeat superior liability. Plaintiff seeks compensatory and punitive damages

from the individual defendants, compensatory damages from the municipal defendant, declaratory relief, an award of costs and attorney's fees, and such other and further relief as the Court deems just and proper.

JURISDICTION & VENUE

2. Within 90 days of the conclusion of the incidents alleged in this complaint, plaintiff served upon defendant City of New York a Notice of Claim setting forth the name and post office address of plaintiff, the nature of the claim, the time when, the place where and the manner in which the claim arose, and the items of damages or injuries claimed.

3. More than 30 days have elapsed since plaintiff's demands and/or claims were presented to defendant City of New York for adjustment and/or payment thereof, and the defendant has neglected and/or refused to make any adjustment and/or payment.

4. Jurisdiction is conferred upon this Court by the aforesaid statutes and 28 U.S.C. §§ 1331 and 1343.

5. Venue is proper here pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1391 because some of the acts in question occurred in Queens County, and Queens County is subject to personal jurisdiction in the Eastern District of New York.

PARTIES

6. Plaintiff Ian Fletcher is an African-American male, who is a resident of the State of New York, Kings County.

7. At all times alleged herein, defendant City of New York was a municipal corporation organized under the laws of the State of New York, which violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

8. At all times alleged herein, defendants NYPD P.O. Esteban; Sgt. Depestre and John/Jane Does #1-10 were New York City Police Officers employed with the 106th Precinct, located in Queens County, New York or other as yet unknown NYPD assignment, who violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

9. The individual defendants are sued in their individual and official capacities.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

10. On August 9, 2014 at and in the vicinity of Rockaway Blvd and the Van Wyck Express Service Road, Queens County, Queens, New York, and the 106th Precinct, Queens, New York, several police officers operating from the 106th Precinct, including, upon information and belief, defendants NYPD P.O. Esteban and Sgt Depestre and John/Jane Does #1-10, at times acting in concert, and at times acting independently, committed the following illegal acts against plaintiff.

11. On August 9, 2014, at approximately 3:10 p.m., at and in the vicinity of Rockaway Blvd and the Van Wyck Express Service Road, Queens County, Queens, New York P.O. Esteban, Sgt Depestre and John/Jane Does #1-10, without either consent, an arrest warrant, a lawful search warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime, unlawfully arrested plaintiff.

12. Plaintiff was driving an ambulette for his employer.

13. Plaintiff was picking up a patient for transport to the patient's dialysis.

14. Plaintiff was driving on Rockaway Blvd, and, after signaling, turned left on to the Van Wyck Expressway Service Lane.

15. After plaintiff completed his turn, he heard the sirens and saw the police in his mirror.

16. Plaintiff pulled over.

17. A police car pulled up behind plaintiff.

18. Two officers in plainclothes exited the police car.

19. A male officer approached the driver's side of the ambulette, and a female officer approached the passenger side.

20. Once the officers stopped plaintiff, plaintiff was not free to disregard the defendants' questions, drive away, or leave the scene.

21. The defendant male officer, falsely accused plaintiff of making a left turn without signaling.

22. Plaintiff advised the officer that he did signal.

23. The defendant male officer asked plaintiff where he was coming from, and plaintiff responded.

24. He then asked plaintiff for his license and registration, and plaintiff complied.

25. The defendant male officer took plaintiff's license and registration, and both officers went back to the police car.

26. Both officers returned to the ambulette.

27. The defendant male officer again asked plaintiff, where he was coming from and where he was going.

28. The defendant male officer also asked plaintiff whether he had a schedule.

29. Plaintiff answered the questions.

30. The officers then ordered plaintiff out of his ambulette.

31. The defendant male officer searched the ambulette.

32. The defendant male officer showed plaintiff a wallet and asked plaintiff who the wallet belonged to.

33. Plaintiff said the wallet was his.

34. The defendant officers emptied the wallet, and said all of the cards in the wallet are fraudulent.

35. Plaintiff informed the defendant officers that the cards were not fraudulent and all belonged to him.

36. The defendant female officer asserted that the cards were all fraudulent.

37. The defendant officers ordered plaintiff to move to the passenger side of the vehicle.

38. Plaintiff complied.

39. Plaintiff attempted to call his office to tell them to send another driver to pick up the vehicle.

40. The defendant officers ordered plaintiff to end the call.

41. The defendant officers then told plaintiff that he would not be working after today.

42. The defendant officers then ordered plaintiff to turn around, and placed excessively tight handcuffs on him.

43. Plaintiff asked the defendant officers to loosen the handcuffs, but the defendant officers did not respond.

44. The defendant officers placed plaintiff into the back of the police car.

45. While plaintiff was in the back of the police car, a man in plainclothes entered the vehicle.

46. The man introduced himself as an NYPD Sgt.

47. He told plaintiff that they were going to take him to the precinct.

48. Plaintiff asked why he was being arrested.

49. The Sgt told him that cards in his possession were fake.

50. Plaintiff was then taken to the precinct.

51. At the precinct, plaintiff was searched, finger printed and processed.

52. Plaintiff requested a phone call, but his request was denied.

53. Plaintiff remained at the 106th Precinct until he was transported to Queens Central Booking.

54. During this time, in order to cover up their illegal actions, the defendant officers, pursuant to a conspiracy, falsely and maliciously told the Queens County District Attorney's Office that plaintiff had committed various crimes.

55. The defendants made these false allegations, despite the fact that they had no evidence that plaintiff had committed a crime.

56. The defendants made these false allegations to cover up their misconduct, to meet productivity goals and quotas, and to justify overtime expenditures.

57. Because there was no basis to arrest or prosecute plaintiff, on October 16, 2014, the case against him terminated in his favor, when all charges against him were dismissed.

58. The individual defendants acted in concert committing the above-described illegal acts toward plaintiff.

59. Plaintiff did not violate any law, regulation, or administrative code; commit any criminal act; or act in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above incidents.

60. At no time prior to, during or after the above incidents were the individual defendants provided with information, or in receipt of a credible or an objectively reasonable complaint from a third person, that plaintiff had violated any law, regulation, or administrative code; committed any criminal act; or acted in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above incidents.

61. The defendants acted under pretense and color of state law and within the scope of their employment. Said acts by said defendants were beyond the scope of their jurisdiction, without authority or law, and in abuse of their powers, and said

defendants acted willfully, knowingly, and with the specific intent to deprive plaintiff of their rights.

62. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' actions, plaintiff experienced personal and physical injuries, pain and suffering, fear, an invasion of privacy, psychological pain, emotional distress, mental anguish, embarrassment, humiliation, and financial loss.

63. Plaintiff is entitled to receive punitive damages from the individual defendants because the individual defendants' actions were motivated by extreme recklessness and indifference to plaintiff's rights.

64. Upon information and belief, the unlawful actions against plaintiff were also based on profiling.

FIRST CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

65. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

66. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, a lawful search warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

67. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth and Fifth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

SECOND CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER STATE LAW)

68. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

69. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, a lawful search warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

70. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under New York State law.

THIRD CLAIM

(UNLAWFUL SEARCH AND SEIZURE UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

71. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

72. Defendants unlawfully stopped and searched plaintiff without cause, a warrant, or consent.

73. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for unlawful search and seizure under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth and Fifth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

FOURTH CLAIM

(UNLAWFUL SEARCH AND SEIZURE UNDER STATE LAW)

74. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

75. Defendants unlawfully stopped and searched plaintiff without cause, a warrant, or consent.

76. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for unlawful search and seizure under New York State law.

FIFTH CLAIM

(UNREASONABLE FORCE)

77. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

78. The individual defendants' use of force upon plaintiff was objectively unreasonable.

79. The individual defendant officers did not have an objective and/or reasonable basis to use any degree of force against plaintiff, since plaintiff was unarmed, compliant, and did not resist arrest.

80. Those defendants who did not touch plaintiff, witnessed these acts, but failed to intervene and protect plaintiff from this conduct.

81. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for using unreasonable and excessive force, pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

SIXTH CLAIM

(ASSAULT)

82. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

83. Among other things as described above, defendants' search and seizure, battery, false arrest, and excessive use of force against plaintiff placed him in fear of imminent harmful and offensive physical contacts.

84. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State Law for assault.

SEVENTH CLAIM

(BATTERY)

85. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

86. Among other things as described above, defendants' search and seizure, false arrest, and excessive use of force against plaintiff were illegal physical contacts.

87. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State Law for battery.

EIGHTH CLAIM

**(NEGLIGENT SUPERVISION, HIRING, MONITORING TRAINING AND
RETENTION OF UNFIT EMPLOYEES)**

88. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

89. Defendant City of New York is liable to the plaintiff because the occurrence and injuries sustained by plaintiff, were caused solely by, and as a result of the malicious, reckless, negligent, and/or intentional conduct of defendant City of New York, and the NYPD and its agents, servants and/or employees, as set forth above, without provocation on the part of plaintiff contributing thereto, specifically, the negligent and reckless manner in which said defendant hired, trained, supervised, controlled, managed, maintained, inspected, and retained its police officers..

NINTH CLAIM

(INTENTIONAL AND NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS)

90. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

91. That by virtue of the occurrence and defendants, individually and/or by their agents, servants and/or employees, negligently and/or intentionally inflicted emotional harm upon plaintiff.

92. The defendants' actions against plaintiff were extreme and outrageous and caused plaintiff severe emotional distress.

93. The defendants breached a duty owed to the plaintiff that either unreasonably endangered plaintiff's

physical safety, or caused the plaintiff to fear for his own safety.

TENTH CLAIM

(NEGLIGENCE AND GROSS NEGLIGENCE)

94. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

95. Defendants are liable to plaintiff because defendants owed plaintiff a cognizable duty of care as a matter of law, and breached that duty.

ELEVENTH CLAIM

(MALICIOUS PROSECUTION UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

96. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

97. The individual defendants are liable to plaintiff for malicious prosecution because prior to any grand jury action, with intent, knowledge, and malice, the defendants initiated a malicious prosecution against plaintiff by drafting and signing a sworn criminal court complaint and police reports that provided false information to the court, alleging plaintiff had committed various crimes.

98. The individual defendants lacked probable cause to believe the above-stated malicious prosecution could succeed.

99. The individual defendants initiated the above-stated malicious prosecution to cover up their illegal and unconstitutional conduct.

100. The above-stated malicious prosecution caused a sufficient post-arraignment liberty restraint on plaintiff.

TWELTH CLAIM

(MALICIOUS PROSECUTION CLAIM UNDER STATE LAW)

101. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

102. The individual defendants are liable to plaintiff for malicious prosecution because, pursuant to a conspiracy and acting with malice, the defendants initiated a malicious prosecution(s) against plaintiff by knowingly, intentionally, and maliciously providing false statements (including signed complaints and police reports) to prosecutors and/or the court(s), which alleged plaintiff had committed various crimes.

103. The individual defendants lacked probable cause to believe the above-stated malicious prosecution(s) could succeed.

104. The individual defendants acted to cover up their illegal and unconstitutional conduct by initiating the above-stated malicious prosecution(s).

THIRTEENTH CLAIM
(FAILURE TO INTERVENE)

105. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

106. Defendants had a reasonable opportunity to prevent the violations of plaintiff's constitutional rights, but they failed to intervene.

107. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for failing to intervene to prevent the violation of plaintiff's constitutional rights.

FOURTEENTH CLAIM
(MONELL CLAIM)

108. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

109. Defendant City of New York, through a policy, practice, and custom, directly caused the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff.

110. Defendant City of New York through the NYPD and its officers, committed the following unconstitutional practices, customs, and policies against plaintiff: (1) unlawfully stopping and searching innocent persons; (2) wrongfully arresting innocent persons in order to meet productivity goals; (3) wrongfully arresting individuals based on pretexts and profiling; (4) using unreasonable force on

individuals; and (5) fabricating evidence against innocent persons.

111. Upon information and belief, defendant City of New York, at all relevant times, was aware that the defendants were unfit officers who have previously committed the acts alleged herein, have a propensity for unconstitutional conduct, or have been inadequately trained.

112. Nevertheless, defendant City of New York exercised deliberate indifference by failing to take remedial action. The City failed to properly train, retrain, supervise, discipline, and monitor the individual defendants and improperly retained and utilized them. Moreover, upon information and belief, defendant City of New York failed to adequately investigate prior complaints filed against the individual defendants.

113. Further, defendant City of New York was aware prior to the incident that the individual defendants (in continuation of its illegal custom, practice, and/or policy) would stop, arrest, and prosecute innocent individuals, based on pretexts and false evidence.

114. The existence of the aforesaid unconstitutional customs and policies may be inferred from repeated occurrences of similar wrongful conduct involving the individual defendants, placing the defendant City of New York on notice of the

individual defendants' propensity to violate the rights of individuals.

115. In addition to frequently violating the civil rights of countless residents of New York City, numerous members of the NYPD commit crimes. Officers have been arrested and convicted of such crimes as planting evidence on suspects, falsifying police reports, perjury, corruption, theft, selling narcotics, smuggling firearms, robbery, fixing tickets, driving under the influence of alcohol, vehicular homicide, assault, and domestic violence. In fact, former NYPD Commissioner Bernard Kerik was convicted of corruption-related crimes in federal and state courts and served time in federal prison. In 2011, Brooklyn South Narcotics Officer Jerry Bowens was convicted of murder and attempted murder in Supreme Court, Kings County, while under indictment for corruption and is presently serving a life sentence. In 2011, Police Officer William Eiseman and his subordinate Police Officer Michael Carsey were convicted of felonies in Supreme Court, New York County, for lying under oath, filing false information to obtain search warrants and performing illegal searches of vehicles and apartments. In 2012, New York City Police Officer Michael Pena was convicted in Supreme Court, New York County, of raping and sexually assaulting a woman at gunpoint and is presently serving a sentence of 75 years to life.

116. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures, and rules of the City of New York and the NYPD were the direct and proximate cause of the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff as alleged herein.

117. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures, and rules of the City of New York and the NYPD were the moving force behind the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff as alleged herein.

118. The City's failure to act resulted in the violation of plaintiff's constitutional rights as described herein.

FIFTEENTH CLAIM
(RESPONDEAT SUPERIOR)

119. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

120. The individual defendants were acting within the scope of their employment as New York City Police Officers when they committed the above described acts against plaintiff, including assaulting, and battering plaintiff.

121. The City of New York is therefore vicariously liable under New York State law for the aforesaid torts.

WHEREFORE, plaintiff demands a jury trial and the following relief jointly and severally against the defendants:

- a. Compensatory damages in an amount to be determined by a jury;
- b. Punitive damages in an amount to be determined by a jury;
- c. Costs, interest and attorney's fees, pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988; and
- d. Such other and further relief as this Court may deem just and proper, including injunctive and declaratory relief.

DATED: New York, New York
April 7, 2015

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